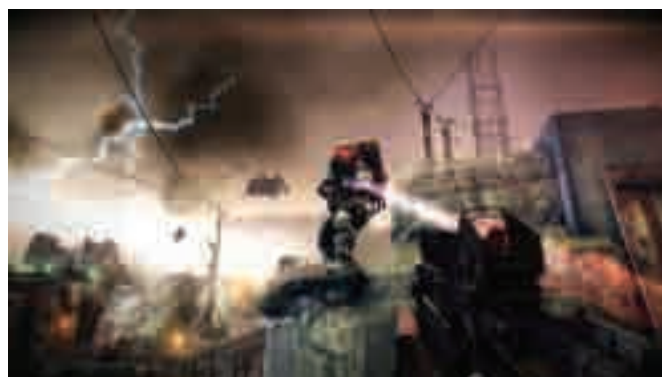


cutscene to figure out that the hackneyed plot is an insult to the intelligence. The lead characters are as one-dimensional as you can get, with Narville being the largely incompetent captain (albeit with good intentions), Rico playing the tough-as-nails-and-as-dumb soldier whose primary job is to hurl abuses at every opportunity, while Sev is the doodh-se-dhula hero type. K3 reportedly boasts 70+ minutes of cinematics, ostensibly to provide a "movie-like experience". If that's true, it's succeeded beautifully — provided you had a B-grade action flick in mind, that is.

A bigger problem with having cutscenes ever so often is that they disturb the "flow" of the game. For example, in the level that I played, one section had Sev travelling up a freight elevator, whereupon a cutscene jumps in showing a group of Elite Shock Troopers zeroing in on him for a round of hand-to-hand combat. It would have been nice to have a minigame

MAWLed to death

The preview itself features a single level somewhere along the K3 plotline, wherein you face off against a giant war machine called the MAWLR, à la the Scarab in Halo 3. The level starts off by putting you in the middle of a few battles against entrenched Higs to warm you up before the MAWLR makes its grand entrance. To assist you in fighting this titanic contraption, you get to use one of the game's new weapons, the WASP multi-rocket launcher, which fires three homing ordinance in a single round. The objective is to outflank



It's a tough battle, but you're helped along by the unlimited ammo dispenser crates nearby. Though I died several times during the fight, the frequent checkpoints ensured that I didn't have to replay more than a couple of minutes each time. This is a definite plus.

After weakening the MAWLR somewhat, the next target was to get to higher ground in a bid to finish it off. Encountering more Higs along the way, a new weapon was introduced to help me wipe the floor with them: the Minigun. As any Action fan will testify, few things in life are as satisfying as wielding a minigun to



at this point where you fight the bunch unarmed, say by using a combination of punches, kicks, and God of War styled press-the-indicated-button mechanics. Instead, the game chooses to show him despatching the baddies as you merely sit back and watch. Good to look at, yes, and "cinematic" too, but rather pointless. Someone needs to inform Guerilla that all great Action games are about maximizing the action.

the automaton and target its weak points with the WASP while it is distracted by your squad's tanks.

This mini-boss battle makes for an engaging experience. You have to constantly dodge the massive robot's barrage of rockets and mortar, take out its machine gun turrets before they cut you to shreds, and yet find time to shoot at the MAWLR's glass jaw when it's exposed for a few seconds.

wreak havoc on your enemies. If you don't believe me, watch Arnold use one on the police amassed outside the Cyberdyne HQ in Terminator 2. After I dealt with the Higs, I walked over to their machine gun emplacements and grabbed the LMG off the tripod to give the soldiers waiting ahead a taste of their own medicine. Allowing moves like this adds to the enjoyment for sure.

The final phase of the battle involved hopping onto the Intruder dropship waiting for me at the top of the structure, then raining death from above onto the MAWLR. This section played out like a standard rail shooter, where all I had to do was point my gun at the AA defences and take them out while the computer navigated the dropship. Nothing we haven't seen before.

Final thoughts

The 30 minutes or so spent on the preview level were rather enjoyable. The top-notch visuals and sound added to the atmosphere, but you can expect nothing less from a AAA title. The downside is that K3 seems to offer nothing new that other shooters haven't had before. In fact, you could practically take Call of Duty and place it in a Sci-Fi setting, and the results wouldn't be very different from K3.

Based on the preview level, I'd say that Killzone 3 is worth buying for Action junkies and for its co-op player mode, since it's hard to mess that up. Another good reason to buy it would be for the chance to play it with the Move controller if you've bought one, but that will depend to a great extent on how well it's integrated with the game mechanics. If you've had your fill playing the likes of COD and Halo though, this is one title you can safely skip.

The game will be available in three editions: the standard box pack; a Collector's Edition in "SteelBook" packaging (basically, a box that has a steel finish) that includes extra goodies such as a downloadable soundtrack, XMB theme, and extra multiplayer maps; and an extra special Helghast Edition that includes all of the above plus a Helghast Cloaked Marksman action figure, and packages it into a life-size Helghast replica helmet. Unfortunately it's not wearable, because that would be fricking cool — you could have scared the hell out of other motorists while riding around on your scooter. No idea on the Indian or international pricing as of this writing, but the box pack is expected to retail for \$60 (₹3,000 approx), while the Helghast Edition might sell for a whopping \$130 (₹6,500 approx). 